

LAND OF RIVERS AND PLAINS

Europe

Europe is the world's second smallest continent; only Australia is smaller. Yet it has an astonishing variety of landscapes, sliced through by the continent's plentiful rivers, from the east-flowing Danube to the north-flowing Rhine.

Mainland Europe is attached to Asia all the way down its eastern boundary along the line of the ancient Ural Mountains in Russia. To the north, it is fringed by the chilly Arctic Ocean, to the west by the Atlantic Ocean, and to the south by the warm, almost landlocked Mediterranean Sea. The Mediterranean south of the continent is warm and the landscape dry, but it is separated from the damper, cooler north by chain after chain of jagged, high mountains, including the Alps and the Caucasus, which have been thrust up by the northward pressure of the subducting African Plate. To the north of the mountains are rolling, sediment-covered plains, and farther north still are ancient mountains worn smooth and sculpted with deep valleys by glaciers during the last ice ages.

